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LEARNER GUIDE

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Introduction

This guide explains the six leadership topics and supports twelve practical activities. It carries forward the original C904 v3 teaching content, with updated critical framing and original worked examples. Use it as a study text and a practical companion to the slides.

Registration and current course details: <https://www.tertiarycourses.com.sg/leadership-masterclass.html>. Course materials:

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/13AchcaOIRVO3l3nyTAm9_z3yEa3D2t1w

Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Explain leadership and management and choose a behaviour suited to the situation.
- LO2: Use active listening and specific feedback to build a shared understanding.
- LO3: Compare options using evidence, uncertainty and ethical constraints.
- LO4: Create meaningful goals and coach someone toward better performance.
- LO5: Resolve a work disagreement by exploring interests and fair options.
- LO6: Design an inclusive team charter, delegation agreement and personal development plan.

Before You Start — Preparation

What you need

- A printed activity pack or a word processor to complete the editable worksheets.
- A partner or small group for conversation practice.

Verify your setup

Open a blank worksheet and confirm you can write in it. Keep the scenario, instructions and checklist beside it.

Conventions used in every activity

- Fictional practice data is clearly labelled.
- Record UNKNOWN whenever the scenario does not provide evidence.
- Worked examples illustrate possibilities; discuss other defensible choices.

Topic 01 — Leadership Foundations

Self-awareness, emotional regulation, integrity, resilience and change

Topic overview

This topic develops LO1: Explain leadership and management and choose a behaviour suited to the situation. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

Def of Leadership

Leadership is the process of influencing others to achieve a common goal or objective

Leadership involves guiding, inspiring, and motivating individuals or groups to accomplish a task or mission

Effective leadership can lead to increased productivity, employee engagement, and organizational success

Importance of Leadership in Organizations

Leadership is essential for the success of any organization, regardless of its size or industry

Leaders set the tone and direction for the organization, and influence the behavior and performance of their team members

Good leadership can result in increased employee satisfaction, improved customer service, and higher profits

Poor leadership can lead to low morale, high turnover, and a negative work environment

Importance of Leadership in Society

Leadership is also important in society, from politics to education to community organizations

Leaders have the power to shape policies, influence public opinion, and create positive change

Effective leadership can lead to a more just and equitable society, while poor leadership can lead to social unrest and inequality

The Impact of Good Leadership on Organizations

Increased productivity and profitability

Improved employee engagement and retention

Higher customer satisfaction

Improved brand reputation

Increased innovation and creativity

The Impact of Good Leadership on Individuals

Improved job satisfaction and well-being

Higher levels of motivation and engagement

Greater opportunities for personal and professional growth

Increased sense of purpose and fulfillment

Improved work-life balance

The Impact of Bad Leadership on Organizations

Decreased productivity and profitability

High turnover and absenteeism

Low morale and employee dissatisfaction

Poor customer service and damaged reputation

Increased risk of legal and ethical issues

The Impact of Bad Leadership on Individuals

Increased stress and burnout

Low job satisfaction and morale

Negative impact on mental and physical health

Decreased motivation and engagement

Limited opportunities for personal and professional growth

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Steve Jobs, Oprah Winfrey, Nelson Mandela, Indra Nooyi, John Wooden.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Jeffrey Skilling, Elizabeth Holmes, Harvey Weinstein, Travis Kalanick, Martin Shkreli.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Key Traits of Effective Leaders

Self-awareness

Emotional intelligence

Integrity and honesty

Resilience and adaptability

Vision and creativity

Self-Awareness

Self-awareness is the ability to understand one's own thoughts, feelings, and behaviors.

It involves being conscious of one's strengths, weaknesses, biases, and emotions.

Self-awareness is essential for effective leadership because it helps leaders understand how their actions and decisions impact others.

Importance of Self-Awareness for Leaders

Self-awareness helps leaders understand their own strengths and weaknesses, so they can maximize their potential and minimize their limitations.

It enables leaders to recognize their biases and blind spots, and avoid making decisions based on faulty assumptions or incomplete information.

Self-awareness helps leaders build better relationships with their team members, by understanding their needs and perspectives.

It enables leaders to manage their emotions and react appropriately in different situations, avoiding unnecessary conflicts or misunderstandings.

Tools and Strategies for Developing Self-Awareness

Journaling: writing down thoughts and feelings can help leaders gain clarity and insights into their own behavior.

Feedback: soliciting feedback from others can help leaders understand how they are perceived by others and identify areas for improvement.

Assessments: using personality or leadership assessments can help leaders gain a deeper understanding of their own strengths, weaknesses, and preferences.

Coaching: working with a coach or mentor can help leaders develop greater self-awareness and identify strategies for improvement.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Satya Nadella, Oprah Winfrey has credited her success to her self-awareness and ability to learn from her mistakes., Nelson Mandela was known for his emotional intelligence and ability to understand the perspectives of others..

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence is the ability to recognize, understand, and manage one's own emotions, as well as the emotions of others.

It involves being aware of one's own feelings, and being able to express them appropriately.

It also involves being able to empathize with others, and understand their perspectives and needs.

Importance of Emotional Intelligence for Leaders

Emotional intelligence is essential for effective leadership because it helps leaders build better relationships with their team members.

It enables leaders to communicate more effectively, by understanding how their words and actions impact others.

Emotional intelligence helps leaders manage conflicts and difficult situations more effectively, by staying calm and focused.

It also enables leaders to motivate and inspire their team members, by connecting with them on an emotional level.

Tools and Strategies for Developing Emotional Intelligence

Self-reflection: taking time to reflect on one's own emotions and reactions can help develop greater self-awareness.

Active listening: focusing on what others are saying, and trying to understand their perspective, can help develop empathy.

Mindfulness: practicing mindfulness techniques, such as meditation or deep breathing, can help manage emotions and reduce stress.

Emotional regulation: learning techniques to manage and regulate one's own emotions can help improve emotional intelligence

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Barack Obama was known for his emotional intelligence, Mary Barra, Ellen DeGeneres.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Integrity and Honesty

Integrity is the quality of being honest, ethical, and transparent in one's actions and decisions.

Honesty is the quality of being truthful and straightforward in one's communications.

Both integrity and honesty are essential for effective leadership, as they help build trust and credibility with team members and stakeholders.

Importance of Integrity and Honesty for Leaders

Leaders who demonstrate integrity and honesty are more likely to be trusted and respected by their team members and stakeholders.

They are more likely to inspire loyalty and commitment, as team members feel that they can rely on their leader to act in their best interests.

Leaders who are honest and transparent are more likely to receive feedback and support from their team members, which can help improve performance and outcomes.

Leaders who are dishonest or lack integrity risk damaging their reputation and credibility, which can have negative consequences for themselves and their organization.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Warren Buffett, Bill Gates, Mary Barra.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Strategies for Demonstrating Integrity and Honesty

Communicate openly and transparently with team members and stakeholders.

Act ethically and in accordance with established values and principles.

Admit mistakes and take responsibility for actions and decisions.

Hold oneself and others accountable for their actions.

Foster a culture of honesty and transparency within the organization.

Resilience and Adaptability

Resilience is the ability to recover from setbacks, challenges, and adversity.

Adaptability is the ability to adjust to new situations and environments.

Both resilience and adaptability are essential for effective leadership, as they help leaders navigate through uncertain and unpredictable circumstances.

Importance of Resilience and Adaptability for Leaders

Leaders who demonstrate resilience and adaptability are better able to handle change and uncertainty.

They are more likely to inspire confidence and trust in their team members, who look to them for guidance and support during difficult times.

Leaders who are resilient and adaptable are better able to innovate and find new solutions to complex problems.

They are also more likely to build strong and effective teams, as they can recognize and leverage the strengths of their team members in different situations.

Strategies for Building Resilience and Adaptability

Develop a growth mindset: view challenges as opportunities for learning and growth.

Practice self-care: maintain good physical and mental health through exercise, nutrition, and stress-reduction techniques.

Seek out support: build a network of trusted advisors, mentors, and colleagues who can provide guidance and support.

Embrace change: be open to new ideas and approaches, and view change as an opportunity rather than a threat.

Learn from failure: view failure as a learning experience, and use it as a stepping stone to future success.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Satya Nadella, Angela Merkel, Elon Musk.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Vision and Creativity

Vision is the ability to see beyond the present and envision a better future.

Creativity is the ability to generate new ideas and approaches, and to think outside the box.

Both vision and creativity are essential for effective leadership, as they help leaders set direction and inspire innovation.

Importance of Vision and Creativity for Leaders

Leaders who have a clear and compelling vision are better able to align their team members around a common purpose.

They are more likely to inspire commitment and engagement, as team members understand the larger context and significance of their work.

Leaders who are creative and innovative are better able to identify and pursue new opportunities, and stay ahead of competitors.

They are also more likely to develop new solutions to complex problems, and to inspire their team members to think outside the box.

Strategies for Developing Vision and Creativity

Set clear goals and priorities

Encourage experimentation

Embrace diversity

Stay informed

Challenge assumptions

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Jeff Bezos, Malala Yousafzai, Steve Jobs.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Key Skills of Effective Leaders

Communication: the ability to convey ideas and information clearly and persuasively

Decision-making: the ability to make informed and timely decisions based on available information

Delegation: the ability to assign tasks and responsibilities to team members in a way that maximizes their strengths and skills

Motivation: the ability to inspire and motivate team members to achieve their goals

Communication

Communication is the process of sharing information, ideas, and feelings with others.

It involves both verbal and nonverbal forms of expression, and is essential for effective leadership.

Importance of Communication for Leaders

Leaders who communicate effectively are better able to establish trust and credibility with their team members and stakeholders.

They are more likely to inspire motivation and engagement, by clearly communicating the organization's goals and priorities.

Leaders who communicate well are better able to manage conflicts and difficult situations, by facilitating open and honest dialogue.

Effective communication is also essential for building and maintaining relationships with clients, customers, and other external stakeholders.

Strategies for Effective Communication

Active listening: focus on what others are saying, and seek to understand their perspective.

Clarity and concision: communicate in a clear and concise manner, using simple language and avoiding jargon.

Nonverbal communication: be aware of nonverbal cues, such as body language and tone of voice, and use them to reinforce the intended message.

Feedback: seek out feedback from others, and be open to constructive criticism.

Adaptability: be adaptable and flexible in communication styles, to accommodate different audiences and contexts.

Trust is Important for Communication

Reduce an Adversarial Mindset

Reduce Conflict

Increase Cooperation

Increase Teamwork

Develop Trust and Understanding

Drive fear out of the organisation

The reference deck introduces this idea through W. Edwards Deming.

Fear of blame can stop people surfacing problems. Invite concerns and respond constructively while retaining accountability for actions and follow-through.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Indra Nooyi, Jacinda Ardern, Tim Cook.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Decision-Making

Decision-making is the process of making choices between different alternatives.

It involves weighing the pros and cons of different options and selecting the best course of action.

Importance of Decision-Making for Leaders

Effective decision-making is essential for effective leadership, as it helps leaders steer their organizations towards success.

Leaders who make good decisions are more likely to inspire confidence and trust in their team members and stakeholders.

Good decision-making also helps leaders manage risks and opportunities effectively, by identifying and prioritizing the most important issues.

Effective decision-making is also essential for driving innovation and growth, by identifying and pursuing new opportunities and strategies.

Strategies for Effective Decision-Making

Gather information: collect and analyze relevant data and information to inform the decision-making process.

Consider alternatives: generate multiple options and evaluate the pros and cons of each.

Involve others: seek input and feedback from team members and stakeholders to gain diverse perspectives and identify blind spots.

Evaluate risks and benefits: assess the potential risks and benefits of different options, and consider the impact on stakeholders.

Use experience to generate hypotheses, then test them against evidence, stakeholder input and explicit constraints.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Elon Musk, Mary Barra, Bill Gates.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Delegation

Delegation is the process of assigning tasks and responsibilities to others.

Effective delegation involves identifying the right tasks to delegate, selecting the right people for the task, and providing the necessary guidance and support.

Importance of Delegation for Leaders

Effective delegation is essential for effective leadership, as it helps leaders leverage the skills and expertise of their team members.

Leaders who delegate effectively are able to focus on higher-level tasks and strategic priorities, and avoid getting bogged down in details.

Delegation also helps develop the skills and capabilities of team members, by providing opportunities for growth and development.

Effective delegation is also essential for building trust and collaboration within the team, by demonstrating trust and respect for team members' abilities and expertise.

Strategies for Effective Delegation

Identify the right tasks: delegate tasks that are appropriate for the skills and expertise of team members.

Select the right people: assign tasks to team members who have the necessary skills and expertise, and who are interested in the task.

Provide guidance and support: communicate clear expectations and provide the necessary guidance and resources to complete the task.

Set deadlines: establish clear deadlines and expectations for completion.

Monitor progress: check in regularly to monitor progress and provide feedback and support as needed.

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Jeff Bezos, Mary Barra, Sheryl Sandberg.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

Motivation

Motivation is the internal drive or desire to achieve a goal or perform a task.

It is essential for effective leadership, as it helps leaders inspire and engage their team members.

Importance of Motivation for Leaders

Effective leaders are able to motivate and inspire their team members, by creating a sense of purpose and meaning in their work.

Motivated team members are more likely to be engaged and committed, and to go above and beyond to achieve their goals.

Leaders who are able to motivate and inspire their team members are also more likely to build a strong and cohesive team culture, where everyone is aligned around a common purpose.

Motivation is also essential for driving innovation and creativity, by encouraging team members to think outside the box and pursue new opportunities

Strategies for Motivating Team Members

Establish a sense of purpose

Provide recognition and rewards

Encourage autonomy

Foster a positive work environment

Lead by example

Discuss leadership through observable actions

The reference deck uses these public figures as discussion examples: Oprah Winfrey, Tony Hsieh, Simon Sinek.

Discuss a specific, dated action and its effect on stakeholders. A public reputation is not evidence that every leadership behaviour is effective.

Separate the observed action, interpretation and outcome. Seek primary evidence before making claims about a person or organisation.

The Difference Between Leaders and Managers

Leadership provides purpose, direction and commitment; management organises plans, resources and delivery.

Both functions are necessary. One person can lead and manage at different moments. Neither role is inherently superior.

A team leader may invite ideas for a new service, then manage its staffing, budget and quality checks.

Change is inevitable

Changing customer needs, technology and working conditions require teams to adapt.

Leadership gives people a shared purpose, room to raise concerns and a clear way to learn during change.

The Ultimate Test of Leadership

The Leader is a Change Agent

Why People Resist Change?

How to Create a Positive Change

Why People Resist Change

Use to the Job

Habits are Formed

May Create More Work

Focusing on the Negative

Ego - It's Not Their Idea

They Don't Understand Why the Change

It's Not Self-Initiated

Routine Is Disrupted

Fear of the Unknown

The Purpose is Unclear

Fear of Failure

The Advantage is Unclear

It May be a Personal Loss

Tradition is a High Priority

Why People Resist Change

"People resist change only when it involves the possibility of loss." Ronald Heifetz,
Center on Public Leadership, Harvard's Kennedy School of Government

How to Create a Positive Climate for Change

Develop Trust

Make Change a Priority

Understand the History of the Organization

Influence Key Players

Exhibit a Positive Attitude

Open Communications

Develop a Mission Statement

Expand your perspective.

Clarify your values and principles.

Create a vision that will motivate.

Always use participation

It provides direction and challenge.

Publish it, in a version that can be remember.

Revise it every so often

Example of Mission Statement

Mission: "To put a man on the moon by the end of the decade" - John Kennedy

Leadership is a learnable practice

Leadership means helping people make progress toward a shared purpose. A title gives authority, but influence also depends on consistent behaviour and relationships. Develop one observable behaviour at a time: for example, ask two clarifying questions before responding in a meeting. Record what happened and ask a colleague what helped. This is more useful than a vague promise to become inspiring. The learning loop combines experience, feedback and reflection; it is not a personality test. In the course scenario, a manager who routinely interrupts begins by inviting the quieter analyst to speak first.

Framework element	Reflective question
Observe a behaviour	How does observe a behaviour affect the choice in this situation?
Try a small change	How does try a small change affect the choice in this situation?
Request specific feedback	How does request specific feedback affect the choice in this situation?
Reflect and repeat	How does reflect and repeat affect the choice in

	this situation?
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Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Santa Clara University: How to Develop Leadership Skills — <https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/how-to-develop-leadership-skills/>

Choose a style for the situation

Directive behaviour can help when time is short and an unfamiliar task has a clear safe method. Participation can improve understanding when the team holds different information. Coaching helps someone develop judgement; delegation gives ownership when capability and boundaries are clear. Treat styles as choices rather than fixed identities. An urgent service recovery may need a clear coordinator, followed later by a participative review of causes. Avoid using urgency as a permanent reason to exclude input. Ask what the task needs, what the person can do, and how much uncertainty the decision carries.

Framework element	Reflective question
Urgency	How does urgency affect the choice in this situation?
Task familiarity	How does task familiarity affect the choice in this situation?
Decision stakes	How does decision stakes affect the choice in this situation?
Team capability	How does team capability affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Institute of Directors: Leadership in the Workplace — <https://www.iod.com/resources/business-advice/leadership-in-the-workplace/>

Self-awareness into ethical action

Self-awareness involves noticing the gap between intention and impact. Emotional awareness helps a leader pause before responding; integrity requires the chosen response to match stated values. At Meridian Services, a late report triggers a manager's fear of embarrassment. Instead of accusing the analyst of not caring, the manager names the missed deadline, asks about obstacles and agrees a recovery plan. The leader can still uphold a standard while regulating tone. Reflection notes should describe observed events, not diagnose a colleague. Personal strengths are useful starting points but do not excuse harmful behaviour.

Framework element	Reflective question
Trigger	How does trigger affect the choice in this situation?
Emotion	How does emotion affect the choice in this situation?
Interpretation	How does interpretation affect the choice in this situation?
Chosen response	How does chosen response affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Santa Clara University: Essential Leadership Skills — <https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/essential-leadership-skills/>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 1 — Leadership Behaviour Snapshot

Learning outcome: LO1: Explain leadership and management and choose a behaviour suited to the situation.

Goal: In this activity, you will observe impact and select one improvement using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed leadership behaviour snapshot worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

A team lead interrupts colleagues and later discovers that a critical constraint was never discussed. Three team members describe different experiences of the same meeting.

Activity folder: activities/activity-01-leadership-behaviour-snapshot. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. List three observed behaviours from the scenario, keeping fact and interpretation separate. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Identify a strength and one behaviour whose impact differs from the leader's intention. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Choose an alternative response and explain which need it addresses. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

4. Rehearse the alternative in pairs and ask for one specific observation. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Complete a seven-day practice commitment and name a feedback partner. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-01-leadership-behaviour-snapshot/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 2 — Mission and Change Roleplay

Learning outcome: LO1: Explain leadership and management and choose a behaviour suited to the situation.

Goal: In this activity, you will select a style and create shared purpose using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed mission and change roleplay worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Meridian Services is introducing a new handover process. Senior specialists fear losing autonomy; a new colleague needs clear instructions. The customer expects fewer incomplete cases.

Activity folder: activities/activity-02-mission-and-change-roleplay. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

"Creating a Collaborative Environment: A Leadership Roleplay"

Scene: A team meeting at XYZ Corporation. The team is composed of members with diverse backgrounds and skill sets. They are currently working on a crucial project with tight deadlines. The team leader, Sarah, calls for a meeting to discuss progress and address potential roadblocks.

Step-by-step

1. Identify what is changing and what each role fears losing. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Draft a mission statement that describes a shared outcome in one sentence. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Choose directive, participative, coaching or delegating behaviour for each role and justify the choice. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Run a five-minute meeting with a leader, a sceptical specialist and a new colleague. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Agree a limited experiment, an owner and a review date; debrief what improved commitment. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-02-mission-and-change-roleplay/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Topic 02 — Communication and Collaboration

Active listening, clear messages, feedback and cross-team working

Topic overview

This topic develops LO2: Use active listening and specific feedback to build a shared understanding. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

What is communication and collaboration?

Communication and collaboration are essential for success in many aspects of life, including work, relationships, and personal development.

Allow individuals and teams to share ideas, goals, and feedback, while collaboration enables them to work together to achieve common objectives.

What is effective communication?

Active Listening

Listener focuses on the speaker and seeks to understand their message

Helps to ensure that the listener understands the speaker's message and can respond appropriately

Clarity and Conciseness

Use simple languages, avoid using jargon or technical terms, be direct

Helps to avoid confusion and ensure that the message is understood

What is effective communication?

Empathy

Ability to understand and share the feelings of another person

Speaker can build rapport and trust with the listener, which can help to ensure that the message is received positively

Non-verbal Cues

Body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice can convey meaning and emotion

Show sincerity and authenticity

Feedback

Ensure that the message has been received and understood by the listener

Types of Communication

Verbal: Face to face, Video conferencing

Non- Verbal: Facial expressions, Body language

Written: Emails, Reports, Letters

Digital: Instant messaging (Whatsapp/Telegram), Social Media

Example of Effective Communication

Team communication:

In a healthcare setting, a team of doctors, nurses, and other healthcare professionals work together to provide care for a patient with a complex medical condition. Effective communication among team members is crucial for ensuring that everyone has the information they need to make informed decisions and that care is delivered safely and efficiently.

Example of Effective Communication

Business communication:

A manager communicates effectively with their team by providing clear goals and expectations, giving timely feedback, and listening actively to their team members' concerns and ideas. This creates a positive work environment where team members feel valued and supported, leading to increased productivity and job satisfaction.

What is collaboration?

Collaboration refers to the process of working together with others to achieve a common goal or objective

By working together, individuals can achieve common goals more effectively, leverage their collective strengths, and achieve greater success than they would on their own.

Benefits of Collaboration

Increased productivity

Collaboration can lead to increased productivity as team members can share the workload and focus on their respective strengths and skills

Improved decision-making

Having multiple perspectives can help identify potential pitfalls or limitations

Enhanced creativity

Bring about new ideas, approaches, and solutions that may not have been possible through individual efforts

Example of Collaboration

Scientific research collaboration:

A group of researchers from different universities and countries collaborate to conduct a study on a particular topic. They bring their different areas of expertise, resources, and perspectives together to create a more comprehensive understanding of the subject. This collaboration results in the production of high-quality research that advances scientific knowledge.

Example of Collaboration

Business partnership collaboration:

Two companies collaborate to develop a new product or service that leverages the strengths of each company. They bring their different resources, technologies, and expertise to create something that neither company could have created alone. This collaboration results in a product or service that is innovative and attractive to customers, leading to increased revenue and market share for both companies.

Communication & Collaboration

Communication is the foundation of collaboration as it enables individuals to share information, ideas, and feedback with each other.

E.g: Team of designers working on a project for a client. The team members may have different areas of expertise, such as graphic design, web design, and user experience design.

They can leverage their respective strengths and skills to produce high-quality work that is greater than the sum of its parts.

How to Communicate & Collaborate effectively

Establish clear goals and expectations for the project.

Foster open and honest communication among team members.

Listen actively and seek to understand other perspectives.

Use a variety of communication channels to accommodate different preferences and needs.

Be clear and concise in all communications.

How to Communicate & Collaborate effectively

Provide regular updates on progress and milestones.

Encourage feedback and constructive criticism.

Use collaboration tools and technologies to facilitate teamwork and organization.

Respect the contributions and expertise of all team members.

Resolve conflicts promptly and respectfully.

Example of Communication & Collaboration

Team of designers working on a project for a client. The team members may have different areas of expertise, such as graphic design, web design, and user experience design.

They can leverage their respective strengths and skills to produce high-quality work that is greater than the sum of its parts.

Best Practices

Define clear goals and roles

Make sure everyone is aware of the project goals, their role in achieving them, and what is expected of them.

Establish open communication

Encourage open and honest communication among team members by creating a safe space for everyone to express their ideas and opinions.

Best Practices

Use appropriate communication channels

Use the appropriate communication channels for the situation, such as email, phone calls, video conferencing, or instant messaging.

Set communication guidelines

Establish guidelines for how often and in what format team members should communicate, and make sure everyone follows them.

Best Practices

Practice active listening

Listen carefully and attentively to what others are saying, ask questions, and seek clarification to ensure that you understand their perspective.

Provide regular updates

Regularly update the team on progress, issues, and changes in the project, and be transparent about any obstacles or challenges.

Best Practices

Use collaboration tools

Use collaboration tools such as shared documents, project management software, and video conferencing platforms to facilitate teamwork and keep everyone on the same page.

Respect diversity

Embrace and respect diversity among team members, including different opinions, ideas, cultures, and backgrounds.

Best Practices

Foster a positive team culture

Create a positive team culture by celebrating successes, acknowledging individual contributions, and encouraging teamwork and collaboration.

Address conflicts promptly

Address conflicts or issues as soon as they arise, and work collaboratively to find solutions that benefit the team and project.

Handling difficult conversations and giving feedback

Be clear and concise

Use clear and concise language to communicate your message effectively.

Use visuals

Visual aids, such as graphs, charts, and diagrams, can help communicate complex information and make the conversation more engaging and interactive.

Stay focused on the facts

Stick to the facts and avoid personal attacks or emotional language. Use specific examples to support your points.

Handling difficult conversations and giving feedback

Use the "sandwich" approach

Start and end the conversation with positive feedback or appreciation, and sandwich the negative feedback or criticism in between.

Be empathetic

Try to put yourself in the other person's shoes and consider their perspective. Use "I" statements to express how their behavior or actions are affecting you or the team.

Teaching clarification: appreciation used only to soften criticism can obscure the issue. Prefer a specific observation, its effect, the person's perspective and an agreed next action. Give genuine appreciation when it is warranted.

Handling difficult conversations and giving feedback

Be solution-focused

Instead of dwelling on the problem, focus on finding a solution that works for everyone involved. Collaborate with the other person to find a way forward.

Listen actively

Listen carefully to the other person's responses and be open to their perspective. Acknowledge their concerns and feelings.

Follow up

Follow up with the person after the conversation to ensure that they understand the feedback and to check on progress towards a resolution.

Listening closes the understanding gap

Active listening means attending to the speaker, asking open questions and checking the meaning of what was said. A paraphrase is tentative: I hear that the deadline is clear but the data owner is not. Is that right? This lets the other person correct the interpretation. Listening is not the same as agreeing. Once the concern is understood, explain constraints and discuss a workable commitment. In a hybrid meeting, invite remote participants before closing a decision and share a written summary so people can correct errors. Clear communication supports shared work across roles and departments.

Framework element	Reflective question
Invite	How does invite affect the choice in this situation?
Listen	How does listen affect the choice in this situation?
Paraphrase	How does paraphrase affect the choice in this situation?
Check	How does check affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: GoSkills: Leadership Skills — <https://www.goskills.com/leadership-management/resources/leadership-skills>

Feedback that can be acted on

Useful feedback identifies a specific situation and observable behaviour, explains its effect, and invites a response. On Tuesday's handover, the status sheet had no named owner; two colleagues repeated the work. This is more actionable than You are careless. Ask what the person saw and agree a next action, owner and review date. Separate a quality problem from a judgement about character. Deliver sensitive feedback privately; use the group discussion for shared processes. If the issue involves misconduct or a serious policy concern, the ordinary coaching conversation is not a substitute for the organisation's reporting process.

Framework element	Reflective question
Situation	How does situation affect the choice in this situation?
Behaviour	How does behaviour affect the choice in this situation?
Impact	How does impact affect the choice in this situation?
Next agreement	How does next agreement affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Center for Creative Leadership: Leadership Competencies — <https://www.ccl.org/articles/leading-effectively-articles/most-important-leadership-competencies/>

Collaborate across boundaries

Collaboration needs a shared outcome and a clear way to coordinate dependencies. Teams can disagree about a method while supporting the same goal. Meridian's sales and delivery groups create one handover definition: customer scope, acceptance criteria, owner and deadline. They name who decides scope changes and when unresolved issues are raised. A collaboration channel does not replace decision rights. The leader makes expertise visible, invites dissent and records agreements. Keep messages brief enough for the intended audience, but include the assumptions that another team needs to do its work.

Framework element	Reflective question
Shared outcome	How does shared outcome affect the choice in this situation?
Dependencies	How does dependencies affect the choice in this situation?
Decision owner	How does decision owner affect the choice in this situation?
Review rhythm	How does review rhythm affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Coursera: Leadership Skills — <https://www.coursera.org/gb/articles/leadership-skills>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 3 — Active Listening Triads

Learning outcome: LO2: Use active listening and specific feedback to build a shared understanding.

Goal: In this activity, you will check meaning before solving using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed active listening triads worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Delivery says that sales promises dates before checking capacity. Sales says delivery does not reply quickly enough. Each team believes the other ignores customers.

Activity folder: activities/activity-03-active-listening-triads. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. Allocate speaker, listener and observer roles and read the scenario independently. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Let the speaker explain the concern for two minutes without interruption. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Ask two open questions and paraphrase the need without assigning blame. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Invite correction; write the revised shared understanding in the worksheet. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Rotate roles and use the checklist to identify one behaviour to keep and one to improve. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-03-active-listening-triads/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 4 — Feedback and Handover Agreement

Learning outcome: LO2: Use active listening and specific feedback to build a shared understanding.

Goal: In this activity, you will give specific feedback and coordinate work using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed feedback and handover agreement worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

A handover lacked a named owner on Tuesday. Two colleagues repeated the same work and a customer waited an extra day. The colleague says the template had no owner field.

Activity folder: activities/activity-04-feedback-and-handover-agreement. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

NextGen Solutions, a mid-sized software development company, was experiencing a decline in productivity and employee morale due to poor communication and collaboration among different departments. The lack of coordination between teams led to missed deadlines, duplicated work, and inefficiencies. The company's management decided to address these issues by implementing new strategies to foster better communication and collaboration.

How will you resolve these issues?

Step-by-step

1. Separate the event from assumptions about the colleague's attitude. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Draft feedback using situation, behaviour and impact in factual language. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Rehearse privately with a partner and ask for their perspective. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Agree a process improvement and define who owns the next handover. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Write a clear cross-team update with outcome, decision owner, dependency and review date. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-04-feedback-and-handover-agreement/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Topic 03 — Decision Making and Problem Solving

Evidence, options, risk, bias and ethical judgement

Topic overview

This topic develops LO3: Compare options using evidence, uncertainty and ethical constraints. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

Why is decision making and problem solving important?

Effective decision making and problem solving can help organizations achieve their goals and objectives. By making informed decisions and solving problems efficiently, organizations can reduce costs, increase productivity, and improve customer satisfaction.

Why is decision making and problem solving important?

Collaboration, communication, and data-driven decision making - are combined, they can lead to powerful problem-solving strategies. By working together, sharing information, and making decisions based on data, teams can solve even the most complex problems and achieve their goals more effectively.

Decision-making frameworks and models

Rational decision-making model: A systematic and logical approach to decision-making that involves identifying the problem, gathering information, generating alternatives, evaluating alternatives, and selecting the best alternative.

Bounded rationality model: A model that acknowledges that decision-makers have limited information, cognitive capacity, and time, and therefore cannot always make fully rational decisions. Instead, decision-makers use heuristics, or mental shortcuts, to simplify the decision-making process.

Decision-making frameworks and models

Intuitive decision-making model: A model that relies on gut feelings, instincts, and past experiences to make decisions quickly and efficiently, without necessarily following a structured process.

Delphi technique: A decision-making technique that involves a group of experts who provide anonymous feedback on a problem or question. The feedback is then compiled and shared with the group, who then provide further feedback until a consensus is reached.

Decision-making frameworks and models

Cost-benefit analysis: A decision-making tool that compares the costs and benefits of different alternatives to determine the best course of action.

SWOT analysis: A decision-making tool that identifies the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats of a particular course of action, in order to make an informed decision.

Analyzing and Interpreting data

Data analysis is important because it helps organizations make informed decisions based on insights derived from data. By analyzing data, organizations can identify patterns, trends, and relationships that would be difficult to detect otherwise. Data analysis enables organizations to understand their customers, optimize their operations, and improve their products and services. It can also help organizations identify and mitigate risks, and uncover opportunities for growth. Ultimately, data analysis allows organizations to make better decisions that lead to improved outcomes and greater success.

Ways to analyze data

Root cause analysis: Analyze data to identify the root cause of a problem or issue. This involves looking for patterns and trends in the data, and using various tools and techniques to identify the underlying causes of the problem.

Cost-benefit analysis: Analyze data to determine the costs and benefits associated with different options or solutions to a problem. This involves quantifying the potential costs and benefits of each option and comparing them to make an informed decision.

Ways to analyze data

Risk analysis: Analyze data to identify potential risks and assess their likelihood and potential impact. This involves looking for patterns in the data that may indicate areas of high risk, and assessing the probability of different outcomes to inform decision making.

Decision tree analysis: Analyze data to create a decision tree that visually represents the different options, outcomes, and probabilities associated with a decision. This can help to identify the best course of action based on the available data.

Ways to analyze data

SWOT analysis: Analyze data to identify strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats associated with a particular situation. This can help to inform decision making by identifying potential obstacles and opportunities for improvement.

Managing risk and uncertainty

Organizations can reduce the potential for negative outcomes and improve their ability to respond to unexpected challenges.

It also helps decision makers make more informed and strategic decisions that are based on a realistic assessment of potential risks and opportunities.

How to manage risk and uncertainty

Identify potential risks

Identify potential risks by brainstorming with the team and considering factors such as past experience, industry knowledge, and environmental factors

Assess the likelihood and impact of risks

Assess the likelihood and potential impact of each identified risk to determine which ones require the most attention and resources

Develop a risk management plan

Develop a plan for managing each identified risk, which may include strategies such as avoidance, mitigation, transfer, or acceptance

How to manage risk and uncertainty

Create contingency plans:

Create contingency plans in case of unexpected events or risks that were not identified or properly managed.

Use data and analytics:

Use data and analytics to gain insights into potential risks and uncertainties, and to inform decision-making

Communicate effectively:

Communicate risks and uncertainties to stakeholders and team members, including potential impact and management strategies, to ensure everyone is aware and prepared.

Making ethical decisions

Individuals and organizations can make more ethical decisions that are consistent with their values and principles. It helps build trust and credibility with stakeholders and promote a positive organizational culture.

How to make ethical decisions

Identify the ethical issue: Recognize that there is an ethical issue that requires attention, and define the problem clearly.

Gather information: Collect all relevant information related to the ethical issue, including facts, values, and perspectives from all parties involved.

Identify stakeholders: Identify all stakeholders who may be affected by the decision, including employees, customers, suppliers, shareholders, and the broader community.

How to make ethical decisions

4. Evaluate alternative actions: Consider all possible actions that could be taken, and evaluate the ethical implications of each option. Use ethical frameworks to guide your thinking.

5. Choose the best course of action: Based on the evaluation of alternative actions, choose the course of action that aligns with ethical principles and values.

6. Implement the decision: Once a decision has been made, implement it with transparency and clarity. Communicate the decision and the reasoning behind it to all stakeholders.

How to make ethical decisions

7. Monitor and evaluate the decision: Monitor the decision to ensure that it is being implemented effectively and evaluate its outcomes to determine whether it was the right decision.

8. Continuously improve: Use the experience gained from the decision-making process to continuously improve the ethical culture and decision-making processes within the organization.

Make uncertainty visible

Good decisions distinguish evidence from assumptions. A low satisfaction score describes a result; it does not prove which process caused it. Ask how the data was collected, how much is missing and whether the comparison is fair. State what remains unknown rather than filling gaps with confidence. For a reversible choice, a limited pilot may produce useful evidence. For a decision with serious consequences, seek the right expertise and approvals before acting. The decision record names the rationale, key uncertainty and the condition that would justify reconsidering it.

Framework element	Reflective question
Known facts	How does known facts affect the choice in this situation?
Assumptions	How does assumptions affect the choice in this situation?
Missing evidence	How does missing evidence affect the choice in this situation?
Review trigger	How does review trigger affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: IMD: Leadership Skills — <https://www.imd.org/blog/leadership/leadership-skills/>

Weighted options need judgement

A decision matrix makes trade-offs explicit, but the number is only as reliable as its assumptions. For Meridian's supplier decision, service quality is weighted 0.4, cost 0.3 and resilience 0.3. Scores of 4, 3, 4 yield 3.7; scores of 3, 5, 2 yield 3.3. These are invented teaching data, not market results. Change the cost weight to see whether the ranking reverses. Explain score evidence and identify a minimum acceptable standard. An option that fails a non-negotiable ethical or safety constraint should not win merely because another score is high.

Framework element	Reflective question
Define criteria	How does define criteria affect the choice in this situation?
Choose weights	How does choose weights affect the choice in this situation?
Compare scores	How does compare scores affect the choice in this situation?
Check sensitivity	How does check sensitivity affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Original course teaching example.

Ethical decisions consider affected people

An ethical decision considers who benefits, who bears costs and whether the process is fair. Check values and duties before comparing convenience. A manager who wants to share customer information to speed delivery should question access, consent and the minimum information required. Discuss alternatives that achieve the purpose with less harm. Explain the choice in plain language and document unresolved concerns. The public explanation test helps expose inconsistent reasoning, but it does not replace policy, specialist guidance or the rights of affected people. Integrity becomes visible in how the leader handles an inconvenient constraint.

Framework element	Reflective question
Affected groups	How does affected groups affect the choice in this situation?
Duties and values	How does duties and values affect the choice in this situation?
Likely consequences	How does likely consequences affect the choice in this situation?
Defensible choice	How does defensible choice affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Santa Clara University: Essential Leadership Skills — <https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/essential-leadership-skills/>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 5 — Evidence and Decision Matrix

Learning outcome: LO3: Compare options using evidence, uncertainty and ethical constraints.

Goal: In this activity, you will compare alternatives and test assumptions using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed evidence and decision matrix worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Meridian must choose a handover support option. Option A has quality/cost/resilience scores 4/3/4; B has 3/5/2. Scores use a fictional 1–5 scale where higher is better. Weights are 0.4/0.3/0.3.

Activity folder: activities/activity-05-evidence-and-decision-matrix. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. Record the decision, options, criteria and scoring direction before calculating. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Calculate $A = 0.4 \times 4 + 0.3 \times 3 + 0.3 \times 4$ and $B = 0.4 \times 3 + 0.3 \times 5 + 0.3 \times 2$. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Identify missing evidence and one bias that could affect the ratings. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Change weights to 0.2/0.6/0.2 and recalculate: $A = 3.4$ and $B = 4.0$. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

5. Recommend a next action with uncertainty, owner and a condition that would trigger review. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in [activities/activity-05-evidence-and-decision-matrix/README.md](#). Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 6 — Ethical Decision and Premortem

Learning outcome: LO3: Compare options using evidence, uncertainty and ethical constraints.

Goal: In this activity, you will check consequences and failure routes using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed ethical decision and premortem worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

A manager proposes sharing full customer records with a temporary team to accelerate delivery. Some fields are unnecessary for the handover. The deadline is tomorrow.

Activity folder: [activities/activity-06-ethical-decision-and-premortem](#). Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

A company is facing pressure from a potential client to engage in unethical business practices in order to win their business. The CEO has called a meeting with the relevant department heads to discuss the situation and make a decision.

Do a short role play on ethical decisions.

Step-by-step

1. List affected groups and distinguish a desired benefit from possible harm. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Identify policy constraints and write UNKNOWN for permissions you cannot establish. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Generate three options, including reducing the shared fields or changing timing. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Imagine the chosen option failed after one week; list three plausible causes and mitigations. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Document a recommendation, approval route and stop condition; explain it to a peer. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-06-ethical-decision-and-premortem/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Topic 04 — Motivation and Performance

Motivation theories, goals, coaching and fair performance support

Topic overview

This topic develops LO4: Create meaningful goals and coach someone toward better performance. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

Definition of Motivation

The driving force or inner state that stimulates individuals to take action towards achieving their goals.

Motivation is crucial in achieving goals and improving performance. Motivated individuals also tend to have higher levels of job satisfaction, engagement, and commitment, leading to improved productivity, performance, and overall success.

Types of Motivation

Intrinsic motivation: Refers to the inner drive or desire to engage in an activity or behavior for its own sake, rather than for external rewards or incentives.

Extrinsic motivation: Driven by external factors such as rewards, recognition, and social approval, rather than internal factors such as personal growth or self-expression.

Examples of Intrinsic Motivation

Personal growth and development: Some people are motivated to learn and grow, simply for the sake of learning and growing. They enjoy challenging themselves, acquiring new knowledge and skills, and expanding their horizons.

Creativity: Some people are motivated by the desire to create and express themselves. They enjoy engaging in artistic or creative activities, such as writing, painting, or music, simply for the joy of self-expression.

Examples of Intrinsic Motivation

Helping others: Some people are motivated by the desire to help others and make a positive impact in the world. They may volunteer their time, donate money, or engage in other acts of kindness, simply because it makes them feel good to help others.

Curiosity: Some people are motivated by curiosity and the desire to explore and discover. They may be motivated to solve puzzles, explore new places, or uncover new knowledge, simply for the thrill of discovery.

Mastery: Some people are motivated by the desire to master a particular skill or activity. They enjoy the challenge of becoming highly skilled and proficient in a particular domain, whether it be a sport, a musical instrument, or a particular profession.

Examples of Extrinsic Motivation

Money: Many people are motivated to work because they receive a salary or other financial rewards for their efforts. They may work longer hours, take on more challenging tasks, or pursue promotions in order to earn more money.

Grades: Students may be motivated to study hard and perform well in order to earn good grades and avoid negative consequences such as failing a class or disappointing their parents.

Examples of Extrinsic Motivation

Recognition: Employees may be motivated to work harder or achieve better results in order to receive recognition or praise from their managers or peers.

Status: Some people may be motivated to acquire material possessions or social status symbols in order to gain status or social approval. They may pursue expensive cars, designer clothes, or luxury vacations in order to signal their success to others.

Fear of punishment: People may be motivated to comply with rules or regulations in order to avoid punishment or negative consequences. For example, a driver may be motivated to obey traffic laws in order to avoid getting a ticket or causing an accident.

Theories of Motivation

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory

Self-Determination Theory

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Maslow's model groups needs as physiological, safety, belonging, esteem and self-actualisation. It is often shown as a hierarchy.

Use it to ask whether basic conditions, security, connection or growth need attention. Needs overlap and do not follow a fixed sequence for every person.

Example: offering a stretch assignment may not help someone whose schedule repeatedly prevents rest or who feels unsafe speaking up.

Teaching clarification: needs can overlap and differ by context. A hierarchy is a discussion lens, not a diagnostic tool or a fixed sequence that predicts each employee.

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory

Herzberg distinguishes hygiene factors, such as conditions and policy, from motivators such as achievement, responsibility and meaningful work.

Improving poor conditions can reduce dissatisfaction, while richer work and recognition may support satisfaction. Treat this as a lens, not a rule that predicts each employee.

Example: fix an unreliable work system, then ask what responsibility or development opportunity would make the task more meaningful.

Self-Determination Theory

Self-determination theory highlights autonomy, competence and relatedness as psychological needs that can support motivation.

Autonomy means a sense of choice within clear boundaries; competence involves effective action and growth; relatedness involves connection and belonging.

Example: agree the required quality standard, let the colleague choose a method, provide practice feedback and connect their contribution to the team's purpose.

Factors that Affect Motivation

Personal values and goals: Personal values and goals can strongly influence motivation. When an individual's values and goals are aligned with their work or other activities, they are more likely to be motivated.

Self-efficacy: The belief in one's ability to accomplish tasks can have a significant impact on motivation. When an individual feels confident in their abilities, they are more likely to be motivated to take on challenging tasks.

Factors that Affect Motivation

Rewards and incentives: Rewards and incentives, such as bonuses, promotions, or recognition, can motivate individuals to work harder and achieve more.

Feedback and recognition: Positive feedback and recognition for a job well done can increase motivation, while negative feedback or lack of recognition can decrease motivation.

Factors that Affect Motivation

Organizational culture and leadership:

Organizational culture and leadership style can impact motivation. A positive and supportive work culture and leadership style can enhance motivation, while a negative or unsupportive work culture or leadership style can decrease motivation.

Stress and workload:

Excessive stress and workload can lead to burnout and decrease motivation, while appropriate levels of stress and workload can enhance motivation.

Strategies for Motivating Others

Set clear goals and expectations: Clear and specific goals help individuals to focus their efforts and understand what is expected of them. This helps to increase motivation by providing a sense of direction and purpose.

Provide feedback and recognition: Positive feedback and recognition for a job well done can increase motivation and encourage individuals to continue to perform well.

Offer rewards and incentives: Rewards and incentives can motivate individuals to work harder and achieve more. These can include bonuses, promotions, or other forms of recognition.

Strategies for Motivating Others

Encourage learning and development: Providing opportunities for learning and development can increase motivation by allowing individuals to develop new skills and knowledge.

Foster a positive work environment: A positive work environment can enhance motivation by promoting a sense of teamwork, trust, and respect. This includes promoting work-life balance, providing a safe and healthy work environment, and encouraging open communication.

Strategies for Motivating Others

Lead by example: Leaders who exhibit positive behaviors, such as enthusiasm, dedication, and a strong work ethic, can motivate others to do the same.

Provide opportunities for autonomy and decision-making: Giving individuals a sense of autonomy and decision-making power can increase motivation by allowing them to take ownership of their work and feel a sense of control over their tasks.

Setting SMART goals

Specific: Define your goal in specific terms. What exactly do you want to achieve? Be clear and concise.

Measurable: Make sure your goal is measurable, so that you can track your progress and determine whether you have achieved it. Set clear metrics to measure your success.

Achievable: Your goal should be realistic and attainable. Consider your resources, skills, and abilities, and make sure your goal is challenging but also achievable.

Setting SMART goals

Relevant: Your goal should be relevant to your overall objectives and aspirations. It should align with your values, passions, and long-term goals.

Time-bound: Set a specific deadline for achieving your goal. This will help you stay motivated and focused, and will also allow you to measure your progress.

Importance of Performance

Performance can be defined as the measurable output or results of an individual or organization's actions or efforts in achieving their goals

It can be used to identify areas for improvement, adjust strategies and actions, and make necessary changes to ensure success. Therefore, performance is a critical factor in achieving goals and success, and it provides valuable feedback on the effectiveness of one's efforts and actions.

Factors that affect Performance

Skills and abilities: An individual's skills and abilities can affect their performance. If an individual does not possess the necessary skills and abilities to perform a task, their performance may suffer.

Motivation: Motivation is a key factor that can impact performance. Individuals who are motivated to achieve their goals are more likely to perform well.

Training and development: Training and development can enhance an individual's skills and abilities, which can improve their performance.

Factors that affect Performance

Resources: The availability of resources, such as equipment, tools, and technology, can affect performance. If an individual does not have access to the necessary resources, their performance may suffer.

Work environment: The work environment can have a significant impact on performance. A positive work environment that promotes teamwork, communication, and support can enhance performance.

Factors that affect Performance

Feedback and recognition: Providing feedback and recognition for a job well done can increase motivation and enhance performance.

Workload and stress: Excessive workload and stress can lead to burnout and decrease performance. Appropriate levels of workload and stress can enhance performance.

Strategies for Improving Performance

Goal Setting: Setting specific, measurable, attainable, relevant, and time-bound goals can help to focus efforts and provide motivation for improving performance.

Time Management: Managing time effectively can help to reduce stress, increase productivity, and improve overall performance.

Strategies for Improving Performance

Prioritization: Prioritizing tasks based on importance and urgency can help to ensure that the most critical tasks are completed first and that resources are allocated effectively

Communication: Effective communication skills can improve collaboration, reduce misunderstandings, and increase overall performance

Strategies for Improving Performance

Feedback and Evaluation: Receiving and providing feedback can help to identify areas for improvement and track progress toward performance goals

Continuous Learning: Engaging in ongoing learning and development can improve knowledge, skills, and abilities, and increase overall performance

Motivation needs a work diagnosis

The original deck covers intrinsic and extrinsic motivation, Maslow, Herzberg and self-determination theory. Use these as lenses for asking questions, not as a universal checklist that predicts every person. Poor performance can arise from unclear expectations, missing resources or an unrealistic workload rather than low effort. Ask the person what helps them do good work. Meridian's analyst values mastery, so the manager pairs a stretch assignment with coaching and protected practice time. Recognition should describe a contribution and its impact. A reward alone cannot repair a work system that repeatedly frustrates people.

Framework element	Reflective question
Purpose	How does purpose affect the choice in this situation?
Autonomy	How does autonomy affect the choice in this situation?
Capability	How does capability affect the choice in this situation?
Connection	How does connection affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Original course teaching example.

Goals connect purpose to delivery

A meaningful goal translates purpose into an observable result. A target must specify the measure, starting point and time period. Meridian aims to reduce incomplete handovers from 18 of 100 cases to at most 8 of 100 within four weeks. The example is fictional. Track a balancing measure such as time spent per handover so improvement does not simply transfer work elsewhere. Let the person help choose a method within clear boundaries. Review evidence and adjust support instead of assuming that every missed number reflects weak commitment.

Framework element	Reflective question
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Outcome	How does outcome affect the choice in this situation?
Measure	How does measure affect the choice in this situation?
Owner	How does owner affect the choice in this situation?
Review date	How does review date affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: UCD Professional Academy: Leadership Skills —

<https://www.ucd.ie/professionalacademy/resources/15-leadership-skills-that-make-a-good-leader/>

Coaching creates ownership

Coaching helps someone think through a goal and select a next action. Ask what they want to achieve, what is happening now, which options they see and what they will try next. Listen before offering advice. Mentoring can share experience; directing can be appropriate when a clear immediate instruction is needed. Make the choice explicit. In Meridian's weekly check-in, the leader asks the analyst to propose two ways to improve data quality and then agrees a small trial. The next conversation checks the evidence from the trial, rather than asking only whether the task is finished.

Framework element	Reflective question
Goal	How does goal affect the choice in this situation?
Current reality	How does current reality affect the choice in this situation?
Options	How does options affect the choice in this situation?
Commitment	How does commitment affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: UCD Professional Academy: Leadership Skills —

<https://www.ucd.ie/professionalacademy/resources/15-leadership-skills-that-make-a-good-leader/>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 7 — Motivation and SMART Goal Canvas

Learning outcome: LO4: Create meaningful goals and coach someone toward better performance.

Goal: In this activity, you will diagnose barriers and make a useful goal using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed motivation and smart goal canvas worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Incomplete handovers occur in 18 of 100 cases. The team has little practice with the new template and conflicting priorities. The aim is at most 8 incomplete handovers per 100 within four weeks.

Activity folder: activities/activity-07-motivation-and-smart-goal-canvas. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. Check whether the issue involves clarity, resources, capability, workload or motivation. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Use intrinsic/extrinsic and autonomy/capability/connection lenses to form questions, not labels. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Write a SMART goal with baseline, target, owner and time window. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Choose a support action and a balancing measure that reveals transferred workload. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Agree a weekly review and explain how you would revise support if results do not improve. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-07-motivation-and-smart-goal-canvas/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 8 — Coaching and Performance Conversation

Learning outcome: LO4: Create meaningful goals and coach someone toward better performance.

Goal: In this activity, you will create ownership through questions using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed coaching and performance conversation worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

An analyst has missed two quality checks while covering for an absent colleague. They want to improve but feel overloaded. A manager's immediate suggestion is to work faster.

Activity folder: activities/activity-08-coaching-and-performance-conversation. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

Set a SMART goal for yourself on one thing you want to achieve this year.

Step-by-step

1. Ask the learner playing the analyst to define the desired outcome. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Explore facts, workload and resources without assuming a lack of effort. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Ask for at least two options before suggesting advice. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

4. Agree one small trial, the leader's support and an observable review measure. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Swap roles and reflect on when coaching, mentoring or a direct instruction would be appropriate. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-08-coaching-and-performance-conversation/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Topic 05 — Conflict Resolution and Negotiation

Conflict patterns, interests, options and emotional steadiness

Topic overview

This topic develops LO5: Resolve a work disagreement by exploring interests and fair options. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

What is conflict and negotiation?

Conflict is a situation where two or more parties have incompatible goals, interests, or opinions, leading to a clash or disagreement. Negotiation is the process of communication and compromise between parties with conflicting interests, in order to reach a mutually beneficial agreement or resolution.

Understanding Conflict

It is important to understand different types of conflicts because it helps individuals and groups to effectively manage and resolve conflicts. Different types of conflicts require different approaches, strategies, and techniques to be resolved.

Types of Conflicts

Personal Conflict

It is a type of conflict that arises within an individual due to opposing values, beliefs, or desires.

Example

An individual is torn between pursuing their passion and fulfilling their family's expectations.

Types of Conflicts

Organizational Conflict

A conflict that arises within an organization due to differences in goals, objectives, or resources

Example

A situation where two departments within a company have different goals or priorities that clash with each other. For instance, the marketing department may want to invest more resources in promoting a new product, while the finance department may prioritize cost-cutting measures.

Types of Conflicts

Inter-group Conflict

A conflict between two or more groups within an organization

Example

The sales team may focus on aggressive sales tactics to generate revenue, while the customer service team prioritizes building long-term relationships with clients. This conflict could lead to tensions between the teams, miscommunication, and a lack of cooperation

Types of Conflicts

Intra-group Conflict

A conflict within a single group due to differences in opinions or interests

Example

Members of a marketing team may have differing views on the messaging or design for a new advertising campaign. This conflict could lead to disagreements, delays, and a lack of cohesion within the team

Types of Conflicts

Interpersonal Conflict

A conflict between two individuals due to differences in opinions, beliefs, or attitudes

Example

One coworker may feel that the other is not contributing enough to a project, while the other may feel that they are being unfairly criticized or micromanaged. This conflict could lead to tension, resentment, and a breakdown in communication between the two coworkers

Types of Conflicts

Intrapersonal Conflict

A conflict that arises within an individual due to conflicting goals or values

Example

A person may have the opportunity to take a high-paying job in a field they are not passionate about, or to continue in a lower-paying job that aligns with their personal interests and values. This conflict could lead to feelings of uncertainty, anxiety, and indecision within the individual.

Understanding Causes of Conflicts

Understanding the causes of conflicts is crucial for promoting peace and finding sustainable solutions to complex issues. By identifying the root causes of conflicts, we can address underlying grievances, prevent future conflicts from arising, and promote reconciliation between conflicting parties.

Causes of Conflicts

Miscommunication

Such as misunderstandings, lack of clarity, or different interpretations of information

Example

A manager sent an email to their team with a deadline for a project, but the deadline was not clearly communicated. Some team members assumed that the deadline was flexible, while others believed it was firm. As a result, some team members submitted their work late, while others completed it on time. This miscommunication created tension within the team and caused delays in completing the project, which could have been avoided with clearer communication from the manager.

Causes of Conflicts

Differences in Values or Beliefs

Such as differing opinions on politics, religion, or social issues

Example

The controversy surrounding Chick-fil-A, a fast-food chain based in the United States. The company's owner, Dan Cathy, is a devout Christian who has publicly spoken out against same-sex marriage and has made donations to organizations that oppose it. This stance has led to boycotts and protests against the chain, as well as praise and support from others who share the same values.

Causes of Conflicts

Scarce Resources

Such as competition for funding, materials, or space

Example

The shortage of computer chips that has affected many industries in recent years, including the automotive industry, consumer electronics, and home appliances. The shortage is a result of various factors, including the COVID-19 pandemic, the increasing demand for electronic devices, and supply chain disruptions.

Causes of Conflicts

Personality Differences

Such as clashes in communication styles, working habits, or attitudes

Example

Extroverted employees may prefer to work in teams or engage in brainstorming sessions, while introverted employees may prefer to work alone or communicate through written channels rather than in-person meetings.

In some cases, these personality differences can lead to conflict, with extroverted employees feeling frustrated by introverted colleagues who do not seem to be contributing as much to the team, and introverted employees feeling overwhelmed or overlooked by the more outgoing members of the team.

Causes of Conflicts

Power Struggles

Such as competition for authority or control

Example

The ongoing feud between Tesla and various state auto dealer associations in the United States. Tesla's business model involves selling cars directly to consumers through company-owned showrooms, rather than through franchised dealerships, which is the traditional model used by most automakers. This has led to conflicts with state auto dealer associations, which have lobbied for laws and regulations that restrict or prohibit Tesla's direct sales model. The power struggle between Tesla and the auto dealer associations highlights the tension that can arise when a new entrant disrupts established industry norms, and the challenges that can arise when entrenched interests seek to protect their own power and influence.

Importance of Conflict Resolution Techniques

By using effective conflict resolution techniques, businesses can help prevent these negative outcomes and create a more positive and productive work environment.

Conflict resolution techniques can also help improve communication and collaboration among employees, leading to more effective teamwork and better overall performance.

Conflict Resolution Techniques

Collaborating

Working together to find a mutually beneficial solution to the conflict

Example

The partnership between Apple and Nike to create the Nike+ app for Apple's iOS operating system. The app, which allows users to track their fitness goals and monitor their progress, was developed through a collaborative effort between the two companies. The collaboration involved sharing expertise and resources to create a product that leverages the strengths of both companies. This can lead to increased innovation, improved performance, and a more positive and productive work environment.

Conflict Resolution Techniques

Competing

Asserting one's own needs and goals over others

Example

Coca Cola Vs Pepsi

The competing resolution technique in this example involves each company striving to outperform the other through competition and rivalry. While this approach can sometimes lead to negative outcomes, such as excessive marketing spending or negative public relations, it can also lead to positive outcomes such as increased innovation and improved product quality.

Conflict Resolution Techniques

Avoiding

Avoiding the conflict altogether by withdrawing from the situation

Example

The lack of action by a manager to address ongoing conflicts between two employees. The manager may be aware of the conflicts, but chooses to avoid confrontation or taking action to resolve the situation, hoping that the conflicts will resolve themselves over time.

Conflict Resolution Techniques

Compromising

Involves finding a middle ground by both parties giving up something to reach a solution

Example

In 2018, American Airlines reached a compromise with its flight attendants union over a new contract. The agreement included pay raises and improved benefits for flight attendants, while also addressing the company's concerns around cost control and operational efficiency.

Conflict Resolution Techniques

Accommodating

Involves putting the needs and goals of others before one's own

Example

A manager who agrees to allow an employee to work flexible hours to accommodate their personal needs. For example, if an employee has a child with a medical condition that requires frequent doctor's appointments, the manager may allow the employee to work from home or adjust their hours to accommodate these appointments

By showing flexibility and empathy, managers can help employees overcome personal challenges while still maintaining high standards of performance and meeting the needs of the organization.

Understanding Negotiation Techniques

Learning different types of negotiation techniques is important because it allows individuals to be more effective in achieving their goals in a variety of situations. Negotiation is a key component of both personal and professional relationships, and being skilled in various techniques can help individuals navigate difficult conversations, resolve conflicts, and create mutually beneficial agreements.

Types of Negotiation Techniques

Distributive Negotiation

Involves dividing a fixed amount of resources between the parties

Example

Where two parties are negotiating the price of a car. In this scenario, the seller wants to receive the highest possible price for the car, while the buyer wants to pay the lowest possible price.

Types of Negotiation Techniques

Integrative Negotiation

Involves finding a solution that meets the needs and goals of both parties

Example

Two companies are negotiating a partnership agreement. Such as, both parties want to create a mutually beneficial agreement that meets the needs and interests of both companies.

Types of Negotiation Techniques

Cooperative Negotiation

Involves working together to achieve a common goal

Example

A landlord and tenant are negotiating a lease renewal. Both parties have a strong interest in maintaining a positive ongoing relationship, and are working to find a mutually beneficial solution.

Types of Negotiation Techniques

Competitive Negotiation

Involves using aggressive tactics to achieve one's own goals

Example

A situation where two companies are bidding for a contract. Both parties work to make their offer more attractive than their competitor's offer. Success in this type of negotiation is often determined by the parties' ability to make strategic moves that highlight their strengths and undermine their competitor's position

Types of Negotiation Techniques

Collaborative Negotiation

Involves working together to create a win-win solution

Example

A group of employees and their manager are negotiating a new policy that will affect their working conditions. In this scenario, both parties have a shared interest in finding a solution that benefits everyone involved.

Understanding managing difficult conversations and emotions

Knowing how to manage difficult conversations and emotions is important because it helps individuals to communicate effectively in challenging situations, maintain positive relationships, and achieve better outcomes.

Developing these skills can lead to improved communication, stronger relationships, and better outcomes in both personal and professional contexts

Managing difficult conversations and emotions

Understanding emotions

Recognize when you/speaker are feeling angry, anxious, or frustrated, and identify the triggers that caused these emotions

How to recognize emotions

Pay attention to non-verbal cues

Label and validate the emotions

Active listening

Mindfulness

Managing difficult conversations and emotions

Preparing for the conversation

Creating a list of talking points or practicing assertiveness techniques

Active Listening

Full attention

Avoid interrupting

Ask open ended questions

Avoid judgement

Managing difficult conversations and emotions

Assertiveness

Expressing oneself clearly, standing up for one's own needs, and setting boundaries

Using "I" statements and avoiding accusatory language

Managing Emotions

Deep breathing, taking a break, and reframing the situation

Helping the other person manage their emotions, such as acknowledging their feelings and staying calm

Managing difficult conversations and emotions

Finding Common Ground

Focusing on shared goals and interests

Brainstorming solutions and using empathy

From positions to interests

A position is what a party says it wants; an interest is why that outcome matters. Sales asks for a Friday launch while delivery asks for two more weeks. The underlying interests may be keeping a customer commitment and protecting quality. Explore a limited launch or a revised acceptance scope, then compare options using criteria both parties understand. Ask questions without assuming the first stated demand is the only acceptable outcome. Some disagreements cannot be resolved by compromise alone; a decision owner may need to choose and explain the reasons.

Framework element	Reflective question
Stated demand	How does stated demand affect the choice in this situation?
Underlying need	How does underlying need affect the choice in this situation?
Possible options	How does possible options affect the choice in this situation?
Fair criteria	How does fair criteria affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Original course teaching example.

Conflict responses have trade-offs

Conflict may concern tasks, processes, resources or relationships. A response should fit the stakes and the time available. Collaboration can produce a better answer when both parties can participate; a pause helps when emotions prevent a useful discussion, but should include a restart time. Accommodating a minor preference may preserve energy for a more important issue. Avoidance becomes harmful when it hides recurring damage. A leader should address observable behaviour and its effect, rather than attributing motive. Use the agreed escalation route when authority, conduct or policy makes peer negotiation insufficient.

Framework element	Reflective question
Address now	How does address now affect the choice in this situation?
Collaborate	How does collaborate affect the choice in this situation?
Accommodate	How does accommodate affect the choice in this situation?
Pause with a plan	How does pause with a plan affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Original course teaching example.

Keep a difficult conversation constructive

Emotional steadiness helps a leader manage a disagreement without silencing it. Prepare the facts, name the shared purpose and invite the other person's account. Acknowledge concern without accepting an unsupported allegation. If discussion becomes unproductive, pause and agree when to return. Record the action and the review point in neutral language. At Meridian, the leader separates a delayed handover from a personal accusation, then checks workload and decision ownership. The goal is a usable agreement and a fair process, rather than winning a debate.

Framework element	Reflective question
Prepare facts	How does prepare facts affect the choice in this situation?
Acknowledge emotion	How does acknowledge emotion affect the choice in this situation?
Explore perspective	How does explore perspective affect the choice in this situation?
Agree next action	How does agree next action affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: GoSkills: Leadership Skills — <https://www.goskills.com/leadership-management/resources/leadership-skills>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 9 — Conflict Diagnosis and Resolution

Learning outcome: LO5: Resolve a work disagreement by exploring interests and fair options.

Goal: In this activity, you will choose a proportionate response using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed conflict diagnosis and resolution worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Sales and delivery dispute who should handle a scope change. Sales sees a customer relationship issue; delivery sees extra work outside the contract. Public messages have become personal.

Activity folder: activities/activity-09-conflict-diagnosis-and-resolution. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. Separate task, process, resource and relationship elements in the disagreement. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Write a neutral problem statement and invite each perspective. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Choose a response based on stakes, time and willingness to engage. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Rehearse a constructive opening and a pause-and-restart phrase if emotions rise. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

5. Agree an action, owner and review, or record the appropriate escalation route. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-09-conflict-diagnosis-and-resolution/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 10 — Interest-Based Negotiation

Learning outcome: LO5: Resolve a work disagreement by exploring interests and fair options.

Goal: In this activity, you will create options and evaluate a fair agreement using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed interest-based negotiation worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Sales wants a Friday launch; delivery requests two weeks. The customer needs one feature Friday, not the full rollout. Delivery can safely pilot that feature with ten users.

Activity folder: activities/activity-10-interest-based-negotiation. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

Scene: An office setting at Creative Marketing Solutions. Two team members, Jane and Kevin, are working on a marketing campaign for a client. They have different opinions on the campaign's creative direction, which has led to a disagreement.

Use one of the Negotiation Techniques to resolve the issue

Step-by-step

1. Record each party's position and ask why it matters. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Identify at least two shared interests and one unresolved constraint. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Generate three options before selecting one; include a limited pilot. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Compare options against agreed criteria and define each party's realistic fallback. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Draft an agreement with scope, owners, dates and what happens if the pilot is not ready. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in [activities/activity-10-interest-based-negotiation/README.md](#). Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Topic 06 — Team Building and Management

Team roles, inclusion, delegation, trust and accountability

Topic overview

This topic develops LO6: Design an inclusive team charter, delegation agreement and personal development plan. Use the explanations below to reason about a response before beginning the activities.

What is team building and management?

Team building refers to the process of enhancing the relationships and communication within a group of individuals working together towards a common goal.

Team management, on the other hand, involves overseeing and guiding the group towards successful outcomes, including tasks delegation, conflict resolution, and motivation.

Both concepts are essential for creating and maintaining effective and productive teams in various settings, such as in the workplace or in sports.

Building High-Performing Teams

High-performing teams are more productive, make better decisions, and have improved morale. By fostering a positive and collaborative team environment, organizations can achieve greater success and reach their goals more effectively. Building high-performing teams requires skills such as effective communication, conflict resolution, and the ability to motivate and empower team members.

Building High-Performing Teams

Understanding High-Performing Teams

Clear goals

Open Communication

Trust and Respect

Collaboration

Accountability

Continuous improvement

Benefits of Building High-Performing Teams

Increased productivity

High-performing teams are able to work together more effectively, which leads to increased productivity

Improved decision-making

When team members work together and share their diverse perspectives, they are more likely to arrive at well-informed and effective decisions

Enhanced creativity and innovation

Team members are able to collaborate and share their ideas, they can come up with new and innovative solutions to challenges and problems

Understanding diversity and inclusion

Both diversity and inclusion are crucial in the workplace. A diverse workforce brings together a range of perspectives, experiences, and ideas, which can lead to increased creativity and innovation, better decision-making, and improved problem-solving.

Inclusion ensures that all employees feel comfortable being themselves and can contribute to their fullest potential. It also helps to reduce bias and discrimination, increase employee engagement and retention, and promote a positive workplace culture.

Benefits of diversity and inclusion

Increased creativity and innovation due to a wider range of perspectives, experiences, and ideas

Improved problem-solving and decision-making due to diverse viewpoints and approaches

Enhanced cultural competence and ability to work effectively in a global and diverse business landscape

Benefits of diversity and inclusion

Increased employee engagement, retention, and job satisfaction

Reduced bias and discrimination, creating a more positive workplace culture

Attracting and retaining top talent from diverse backgrounds

Enhanced reputation and brand image as a socially responsible and inclusive organization.

Benefits of diversity and inclusion

Improved customer relations and satisfaction by reflecting the diversity of the customer base

Increased profitability and business success due to the above benefits

Barriers of diversity and inclusion

Unconscious bias

Lack of diversity in leadership

Stereotyping and discrimination

Resistance to change

Limited access to opportunities

Language and cultural barriers

Lack of accountability

Lack of support and resources

Strategies for managing diversity and inclusion

Develop a diversity and inclusion strategy

Develop a clear strategy that outlines the organization's goals, objectives, and action plan for promoting diversity and inclusion

Conduct diversity training

Provide diversity training to all employees to help them recognize and overcome unconscious bias and develop cultural competence

Foster an inclusive culture

Foster an inclusive workplace culture by promoting respect, open communication, and teamwork across all levels of the organization

Strategies for managing diversity and inclusion

Provide equal opportunities

Ensure that all employees have equal access to opportunities such as training, mentoring, and career advancement

Recruit and retain diverse talent

Develop recruitment and retention strategies that attract and retain diverse talent

Provide employee resource groups

Employee resource groups (ERGs) provide a forum for employees to connect and support each other based on shared interests or identities

Strategies for managing diversity and inclusion

Encourage feedback

Encourage employees to provide feedback and suggestions for how the organization can better promote diversity and inclusion

Hold leadership accountable

Hold leadership accountable for promoting diversity and inclusion by setting goals, tracking progress, and providing resources and support

Monitor progress

Monitor progress towards diversity and inclusion goals, and adjust strategies as needed to ensure continued progress

Best practices for managing diversity and inclusion

Leadership commitment

Diversity and inclusion must be a top-down initiative that starts with leadership commitment to creating an inclusive culture

Consistent communication

Communicate regularly and consistently about the organization's commitment to diversity and inclusion, and provide updates on progress and successes

Inclusive policies and practices

Review and update policies and practices to ensure they are inclusive, such as flexible work arrangements, parental leave, and accommodations for disabilities

Best practices for managing diversity and inclusion

Fairness and equity

Ensure that all employees are treated fairly and equitably, regardless of their backgrounds or identities

Employee involvement

Involve employees in the development and implementation of diversity and inclusion initiatives, such as employee resource groups or diversity task forces

Continuous learning

Encourage continuous learning and education about diversity and inclusion, such as providing training and resources for employees to learn about different cultures, backgrounds, and experiences

Best practices for managing diversity and inclusion

Metrics and accountability

Develop metrics to track progress towards diversity and inclusion goals, and hold leadership and managers accountable for promoting diversity and inclusion in their areas

Celebrate diversity

Celebrate diversity and cultural events, such as Black History Month, Pride Month, or International Women's Day, to create a sense of belonging and inclusion for all employees

Ongoing evaluation

Continuously evaluate diversity and inclusion initiatives and strategies to ensure their effectiveness and make necessary changes to better promote diversity and inclusion in the organization

Measuring Success

Employee Engagement

Turnover rates

Productivity & Profitability

Customer satisfaction

Team dynamics and roles

Team dynamics

The way team members interact and work together

Influenced by factors such as personality, communication styles, and the team's goals and objectives

Team dynamics and roles can shift and change over time based on the team's needs and the individuals involved. It's important for team members to have open communication and be flexible in order to adapt to changes in dynamics and roles

Common team dynamics

Trust and psychological safety

Communication and collaboration

Conflict resolution

Cohesion and alignment

Roles within a team

Each team member has a specific role and responsibilities to fulfill

Roles can be based on skill set, expertise, or position within the organization

Common team roles

Leader: responsible for guiding the team and ensuring that goals and objectives are met

Facilitator: responsible for keeping the team on track and facilitating discussions

Expert: brings specific knowledge or expertise to the team

Implementer: responsible for executing the team's plan and completing tasks

Coordinator: responsible for managing logistics and ensuring that everyone is on the same page

Definition of trust and accountability

Trust can be defined as the belief or confidence that one has in another person or entity's reliability, honesty, and competence

Accountability refers to the responsibility that individuals or organizations have for their actions or decisions. It involves being answerable for the outcomes of one's actions and being willing to take responsibility for any mistakes or failures

Both trust and accountability are important in a workplace because they help to create a positive and productive work environment

Benefits of trust and accountability

Increased productivity

When employees trust their colleagues and are held accountable for their work, they are more likely to be productive and engaged. This leads to higher levels of output and better overall performance.

Improved teamwork

A culture of trust and accountability promotes collaboration and teamwork. When employees trust one another, they are more likely to work together effectively and communicate openly and honestly. This leads to better problem-solving and decision-making.

Benefits of trust and accountability

Enhanced creativity

A culture of trust and accountability encourages employees to take risks and be creative in their work. When employees know that they are supported and that they will be held accountable for their actions, they are more likely to think outside the box and come up with innovative ideas

Greater job satisfaction

When employees feel trusted and supported, they are more likely to be satisfied with their job and the organization they work for. This can lead to lower turnover rates and better employee retention

Benefits of trust and accountability

Improved customer relationships

A culture of trust and accountability can also benefit customers. When employees are held accountable for their work, they are more likely to provide high-quality products or services and to treat customers with respect and professionalism

Building trust

Building trust requires consistency, honesty, and reliability. It involves keeping promises, following through on commitments, and being transparent in communication. Trust is built over time through positive interactions and a willingness to listen and understand the perspectives of others.

How to build trust

regular check-ins, active listening, and providing feedback

Maintaining accountability

Maintaining accountability involves setting clear expectations, following through on commitments, and taking responsibility for outcomes. It requires open communication and transparency, being willing to admit mistakes and make necessary corrections.

How to maintain accountability

regular goal-setting, performance evaluations, and recognition programs

Tools for building trust and accountability

Performance reviews

Conduct regular performance reviews that provide feedback on individual performance and progress towards shared goals. This can help build accountability by setting clear expectations and holding individuals responsible for their actions.

Team-building activities

Plan team-building activities that encourage collaboration, communication, and positive interactions. This can help build trust by promoting teamwork and a sense of shared purpose.

Tools for building trust and accountability

Training programs

Offer training programs that promote ethical behavior and professionalism. This can help build accountability by providing individuals with the tools and knowledge they need to make responsible decisions.

Recognition programs

Implement recognition programs that reward individuals and teams for demonstrating trust and accountability. This can help build trust by recognizing and celebrating positive behavior and achievements.

Common barriers to building trust and accountability in the workplace

Lack of communication

When communication is unclear or inconsistent, it can lead to misunderstandings and erode trust. This can also make it difficult to establish clear expectations and hold individuals accountable

Poor leadership

When leaders fail to model trust and accountability, it can undermine these values throughout the organization. Leaders who do not hold themselves or others accountable can create a culture of blame and distrust.

Common barriers to building trust and accountability in the workplace

Inconsistent standards

When standards of behavior and performance are not consistently applied, it can erode trust and undermine accountability. If some individuals are held to a different standard than others, it can create a sense of unfairness and undermine trust

Lack of transparency

When decisions are made behind closed doors or information is withheld, it can erode trust and create a sense of mistrust. Transparency and open communication are essential for building trust and accountability.

Strategies for overcoming these barriers

Improve communication

Establish regular channels of communication that are clear, consistent, and transparent. Encourage feedback and active listening to promote open and honest communication.

Lead by example

Leaders must model the behavior they want to see in others. Hold leaders accountable for their actions and ensure they are consistently demonstrating trust and accountability.

Strategies for overcoming these barriers

Establish consistent standards

Ensure that standards of behavior and performance are consistently applied throughout the organization. Hold individuals accountable for meeting expectations and provide feedback when they fall short.

Foster transparency

Be open and transparent in decision-making and information sharing. Provide regular updates and ensure that everyone is on the same page.

Strategies for overcoming these barriers

Provide training and support

Offer training programs and support to help individuals develop the skills and knowledge they need to make responsible decisions and behave professionally.

Celebrate successes

Recognize and celebrate positive behavior and achievements. This can help build trust and promote a sense of community within the organization.

Strengths complement one another

Gallup describes executing, influencing, relationship building and strategic thinking as four strengths domains. They provide a lens for discussing contributions; they are not a ranking of people. The course worksheet uses observed work examples and does not produce a CliftonStrengths score. Meridian pairs someone skilled at analysis with someone who builds client understanding. Check workload and development needs as well as preference when assigning work. A team needs ways to cover gaps, and a person's apparent strength can be overused. Keep asking what the situation needs and whether colleagues experience the contribution as helpful.

Framework element	Reflective question
Deliver work	How does deliver work affect the choice in this situation?
Build relationships	How does build relationships affect the choice in this situation?
Influence	How does influence affect the choice in this situation?
Think ahead	How does think ahead affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Gallup: How to Be a Better Leader —

<https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/356072/how-to-be-better-leader.aspx>

Delegation is a two-way agreement

Delegation transfers ownership of a result within stated boundaries. Agree what success looks like, which choices the person can make, the resources available and when to raise a problem. The leader remains accountable for the system of support and follow-up. Meridian delegates the handover pilot to an experienced coordinator with authority to revise the template, but not to change customer commitments. Check capability and workload before assigning a stretch task. Too many checkpoints can become micromanagement; too few can hide a problem until the deadline.

Framework element	Reflective question
Result	How does result affect the choice in this situation?
Authority	How does authority affect the choice in this situation?
Resources	How does resources affect the choice in this situation?
Checkpoints	How does checkpoints affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Santa Clara University: Essential Leadership Skills — <https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/essential-leadership-skills/>

Leadership development needs evidence

A development plan should connect a specific behaviour to practice and feedback. Rather than Improve communication, choose Summarise and check the decision at the end of each cross-team meeting. Name the next opportunity, a feedback partner and what would show progress. Include reflection on both success and setbacks. Meridian's team lead collects two examples each week and asks whether the summary helped colleagues act. A course can introduce tools, but repeated work practice and supportive relationships make the change durable. Adjust the plan when the evidence shows that the chosen behaviour is not addressing the real need.

Framework element	Reflective question
One behaviour	How does one behaviour affect the choice in this situation?
Practice opportunity	How does practice opportunity affect the choice in this situation?
Feedback partner	How does feedback partner affect the choice in this situation?
Review evidence	How does review evidence affect the choice in this situation?

Visual companion: the slide deck shows this framework as an editable diagram. Further reading: Coursera: Tips for Developing Leadership Skills — <https://www.coursera.org/enterprise/articles/tips-for-developing-leadership-skills>

Common mistakes and boundaries

Distinguish observed behaviour from assumed motive. A framework organises thinking, but it does not remove uncertainty or choose a response for you. Check task context, capability, workload and affected people; explain what you know and what remains unknown.

Activity 11 — Inclusive Team Charter and Delegation

Learning outcome: LO6: Design an inclusive team charter, delegation agreement and personal development plan.

Goal: In this activity, you will assign ownership and make participation usable using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed inclusive team charter and delegation worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

Meridian's pilot team has an analyst, coordinator, client adviser and new joiner. The analyst is remote. The coordinator is capable but already leads two projects.

Activity folder: activities/activity-11-inclusive-team-charter-and-delegation. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Optional original practice context

The following exercise is retained from the original C904 deck. Discuss it using the same framework after completing the main activity.

Company XYZ is a mid-sized software development firm. The company is experiencing a lot of turnover and the CEO has tasked the HR department with building a high-performing team that will improve productivity and reduce turnover.

What are some of steps that HR department can take to build a high-performing team?

Step-by-step

1. Map each person's observed contribution, workload and development need. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

2. Define shared purpose, decision rights and a norm that includes remote participation. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Draft a delegation agreement covering result, authority, resources and checkpoints. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Test whether the recipient can explain the result and escalation trigger in their own words. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Revise the allocation if workload or missing capability makes the plan unrealistic. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-11-inclusive-team-charter-and-delegation/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Activity 12 — 30-Day Leadership Development Plan

Learning outcome: LO6: Design an inclusive team charter, delegation agreement and personal development plan.

Goal: In this activity, you will convert learning into a measurable habit using a fictional Meridian Services situation. You will discuss different perspectives, practise a leadership response and produce a reusable work artifact. The exercise connects the topic concepts to an everyday team decision, and the debrief focuses on how your response affects other people.

What you'll build

A completed 30-day leadership development plan worksheet, a peer observation checklist and a practical next action. (Tools: Printed worksheets or an editable word processor; pairs or groups of three.)

Fictional scenario

The team lead wants to improve cross-team decisions. Colleagues say meeting summaries are unclear and disagreements are often reopened.

Activity folder: activities/activity-12-30-day-leadership-development-plan. Use the blank worksheet, scenario, illustrative completed worksheet and checklist. The worked example shows one possible response.

Step-by-step

1. Select one observable behaviour linked to a course learning outcome. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
2. Choose a real practice opportunity and a feedback partner who experiences the behaviour. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
3. Write an if–then plan for the trigger most likely to disrupt the habit. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
4. Define evidence, a baseline if available, and reviews on days 7, 14 and 30. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.
5. Explain the plan to a partner, revise vague wording and keep a copy for workplace use. Write your reasoning in the worksheet; compare it with your partner before moving on.

Test it

Check each item in checklist.md, then ask a peer to identify one clear strength and one concrete improvement. Confirm that your proposed action has an owner and a review point.

Note: Standalone instructions and worksheets are in activities/activity-12-30-day-leadership-development-plan/README.md. Use the fictional scenario rather than personal or confidential employee information.

Apply the Learning

Choose one behaviour and use Activity 12 to plan 30 days of practice.

Continue learning

Ask a feedback partner for observations, review the evidence and adapt your next action. Leadership improvement comes from repeated choices and reflection.

Next Steps

- Keep the completed worksheets as reusable templates.
- Try one chosen behaviour in your next team interaction.

- Review evidence with your feedback partner after 7, 14 and 30 days.

Further Reading and Sources

The teaching spine is adapted from the user-supplied C904 reference deck v3. The following sources informed selected extensions. All third-party ideas are paraphrased; the activities and numerical examples are original fictional teaching material. Accessed 2 October 2026.

Santa Clara University: Essential Leadership Skills —

<https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/essential-leadership-skills/>

Santa Clara University: How to Develop Leadership Skills —

<https://www.scu.edu/business/blog/leadership-ethics/how-to-develop-leadership-skills/>

IMD: Leadership Skills — <https://www.imd.org/blog/leadership/leadership-skills/>

UCD Professional Academy: Leadership Skills —

<https://www.ucd.ie/professionalacademy/resources/15-leadership-skills-that-make-a-good-leader/>

Gallup: How to Be a Better Leader —

<https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/356072/how-to-be-better-leader.aspx>

Center for Creative Leadership: Leadership Competencies —

<https://www.ccl.org/articles/leading-effectively-articles/most-important-leadership-competencies/>

GoSkills: Leadership Skills —

<https://www.goskills.com/leadership-management/resources/leadership-skills>

Institute of Directors: Leadership in the Workplace —

<https://www.iod.com/resources/business-advice/leadership-in-the-workplace/>

Coursera: Tips for Developing Leadership Skills —

<https://www.coursera.org/enterprise/articles/tips-for-developing-leadership-skills>

Coursera: Leadership Skills — <https://www.coursera.org/gb/articles/leadership-skills>